

Coinbase Advanced Trade API (V3) – Futures Trading Access

API Key Scope and Portfolio Selection for Futures

Coinbase's Advanced Trade API keys are **portfolio-specific**, meaning each key is tied to a particular trading portfolio ¹. The **"Primary" portfolio (default)** is used for spot trading, while futures (perpetual contracts) reside in a separate **"Perpetuals" portfolio** for eligible users ² ³. In practice, this means you **must create a new API key scoped to the Futures/Perpetuals portfolio** (or use an "All Portfolios" key if Coinbase offers that option) to trade futures. A key that is scoped only to your Primary (spot) portfolio **cannot place orders on futures markets**, and will result in a `PERMISSION_DENIED` error (e.g. "Target Account Not Tradable") if used for futures orders ⁴. Coinbase's own documentation and third-party guides emphasize that **separate API keys are required for Spot vs. Perpetual accounts** on Advanced Trade ⁵. In summary, ensure your API key's **portfolio selection is set to "Perpetuals" (Futures)** – not the default spot portfolio – when creating the key, so it has the proper scope for futures trading ³.

Futures Trading Permission vs. Standard Trade Permission

There is **no special "Futures Trading" checkbox** in the API key permissions – the standard **"Trade" permission** covers the ability to execute orders on any market the key's portfolio has access to ³. In other words, as long as your key is tied to the correct Futures portfolio and has **Trade enabled** (along with View for reading data), it is sufficient. Coinbase's API keys typically have three toggles: View, Trade, and Transfer ⁶ – there isn't a separate futures-specific toggle. However, **enabling futures trading in your account is a prerequisite**: you must complete Coinbase's futures onboarding flow in the Advanced Trade UI (e.g. regulatory disclosures, knowledge checks) before the **"Perpetuals" portfolio becomes available** ² ⁷. Once this is done and you create a key for the Perpetuals portfolio with Trade permission, no additional API permission is needed for futures. (Do double-check that the key was created with the **"Perpetuals" portfolio selected** – if a key is mistakenly created for the default spot portfolio, it will not authorize futures trades even if Trade is enabled.)

Transferring USDC Collateral vs. Auto-Sweep

Collateral must be manually allocated to your Futures portfolio – there is *no automatic sweep* of funds from your spot account to your futures account when trading via API. Coinbase's futures (perpetuals) are **USDC-margined**, so you need USDC in the Perpetuals portfolio to serve as margin for any futures trades ⁸. According to Coinbase's documentation, you should **transfer USDC from your default (Spot) portfolio to your Perpetuals portfolio** before placing orders, using the **"Move Portfolio Funds"** endpoint or the UI ⁸. If you attempt to trade futures without funding that portfolio, you'll encounter errors due to insufficient margin or non-tradable account status. By default, there is no cross-collateralization between portfolios; **funds in the spot wallet are not automatically accessible to the futures wallet** for API trades. (Coinbase *does* offer a **"multi-asset collateral" opt-in** for futures, allowing BTC or ETH to be used as

collateral, but even then you must explicitly opt in and presumably transfer those assets into the Perpetuals portfolio ⁹. There is no implicit cross-use of assets without user action.) In short, **ensure your Perpetuals portfolio is funded with USDC** (or other allowed collateral after opt-in) *before* sending API orders. No auto-sweep is performed by Coinbase's API – you control the transfers.

Required Permissions & Setup for Placing Futures Orders

To successfully place a futures order via the Advanced Trade API (V3), make sure you have completed the following setup:

- **Futures Enabled & Portfolio Created:** Confirm that you're in an **eligible region and have completed the futures onboarding** in Coinbase's Advanced Trade UI ⁷. After enabling, you should see a **"Perpetuals" portfolio** in your account, which is where futures trading occurs ².
- **API Key Tied to Futures Portfolio:** Create a **dedicated API key for the Perpetuals (Futures) portfolio** via the Coinbase Cloud (CDP) API key page. When creating the key, set the Portfolio to "Perpetuals" (instead of "Default") and give it the necessary permissions ³. At minimum, enable **"View" and "Trade"** permissions so the key can read account data and execute orders (Transfer is optional unless you plan to move funds via API). Keep the passphrase/secret as provided.
- **Fund the Futures Portfolio:** Transfer the required **USDC margin** into the Perpetuals portfolio before trading. Use Coinbase's transfer endpoints or UI to move funds from your Primary portfolio to the Perpetuals portfolio ⁸. This ensures the **source account is funded and tradable**; otherwise, order placement will fail due to insufficient collateral.
- **Use Correct Product IDs:** When sending order requests, use the **proper futures market product IDs** (e.g. `BTC-PERP` instead of a spot pair like `BTC-USD`). Coinbase futures contracts are typically denominated in USDC (e.g. BTC-USDC or BTC-PERP) and won't execute on spot USD markets ¹⁰. Using the wrong product or an unsupported currency (like USD in a region that only supports USDC settlement) can cause "account not available" or similar errors ¹⁰.
- **Order Placement via API:** Call the Advanced Trade **POST** `/api/v3/brokerage/orders` endpoint with your JWT authentication headers and order payload. Because your API key is already scoped to the correct portfolio, you usually **do not need to specify a `portfolio_id`** in the request – the system defaults to the key's own portfolio ¹¹. (In the past, a `retail_portfolio_id` field could target specific portfolios, but for current API keys this parameter is deprecated and not required for the assigned portfolio ¹¹.) If using a library like CCXT, ensure it's up-to-date; older versions might not handle multiple portfolios and could require manually passing the portfolio ID in requests ¹². An up-to-date library or direct API call with a portfolio-scoped key should place the order in the correct account.

By following the above steps, your API requests should have the proper scope and permissions to execute Futures trades. In summary, **use a Futures-designated API key with Trade permission, fund that futures portfolio with USDC, and then place orders on the USDC-perpetual markets**. With the correct setup, the Advanced Trade API will accept your futures orders; any `PERMISSION_DENIED` errors indicate a likely misconfiguration in key scope or permissions (for example, using a Spot key or an unfunded portfolio) ¹³. Always double-check that the key's **portfolio UUID corresponds to your "INTX" (perpetuals) account** and that you've met all onboarding requirements for derivatives trading on Coinbase ⁷. This will ensure you have the expected permissions and access needed to place futures orders successfully through the V3 API.

Sources: Coinbase Advanced Trade developer docs on portfolios and international derivatives ¹ ⁸ ; Coinbase Cloud community and third-party guides confirming separate API keys for futures ⁵ ³ ; and Coinbase help articles on enabling futures and funding collateral ² ⁸ .

¹ Advanced Trade Portfolios - Coinbase Developer Documentation

<https://docs.cdp.coinbase.com/coinbase-app/advanced-trade-apis/guides/portfolios>

² How to Create and Set Up Coinbase Advanced API Key | Bitsgap

<https://bitsgap.com/helpdesk/article/9872088623516-How-to-Create-and-Set-Up-Coinbase-Advanced-API-Key>

³ ⁵ Coinbase Advanced: How to Create API Keys | 3Commas Help Center

<https://help.3commas.io/en/articles/8228623-coinbase-advanced-how-to-create-api-keys>

⁴ ¹² Additional arguments needed for trading in other than default portfolio on coinbase advanced trade · Issue #22073 · ccxt/ccxt · GitHub

<https://github.com/ccxt/ccxt/issues/22073>

⁶ Get API Key Permissions - Coinbase Developer Documentation

<https://docs.cdp.coinbase.com/api-reference/advanced-trade-api/rest-api/data-api/get-api-key-permissions>

⁷ ⁸ ⁹ Advanced Trade International Derivatives - Coinbase Developer Documentation

<https://docs.cdp.coinbase.com/coinbase-app/advanced-trade-apis/guides/perpetual>

¹⁰ python - Coinbase Advance Trading API returns "Error: account not available" when placing orders - Stack Overflow

<https://stackoverflow.com/questions/78726982/coinbase-advance-trading-api-returns-error-account-not-available-when-placing>

¹¹ List Orders - Coinbase Developer Documentation

<https://docs.cdp.coinbase.com/api-reference/advanced-trade-api/rest-api/orders/list-orders>

¹³ Advanced Trading API limit order issues : r/CoinBase

https://www.reddit.com/r/CoinBase/comments/zf35zh/advanced_trading_api_limit_order_issues/